

The Sunday Edit

2 August 2026

Good morning. Here's everything worth reading this week — with a few things to put in the diary.

This Week's Big Read

The Mayor of Scamtown

There is a small town north of Manila called Bamban — population 80,000, low-rise buildings, corrugated-iron shacks, the occasional cart of freshwater snails cooked in coconut milk. Until a few years ago, almost no one outside Tarlac province had heard of it. Then Alice Guo became mayor, and everything changed.

Guo arrived as a dynamo. Young, personable, she went around addressing town elders as *lolo* (grandfather) and *tito* (uncle). Fast-food chains — Jollibee, 7-Eleven, KFC — that had never bothered with Bamban arrived under her watch. Locals saw a local girl made good.

Then, in 2021, Guo started arriving by helicopter.

Her explanation — “new business partner” — satisfied no one, but curiosity has its limits in small Filipino towns. She ran for mayor in 2022 and won. It was only in March 2024, after a police raid on a compound at the edge of town, that the full picture emerged. Inside ten hectares of fencing, the authorities found 36 buildings and hundreds of coerced workers — mostly Chinese nationals — running “pig butchering” scams. The operation worked like this: workers posed as potential lovers on social media, built months-long relationships with their marks, then reeled them into fraudulent investment schemes. Hundreds of millions of dollars vanished from lonely people across the globe.

Guo, it turned out, was not Alice Guo at all. She was Guo Hua Ping, a Chinese national who had fabricated a Filipino identity complete with forged birth certificates. The compound in Bamban was one node in a network of similar facilities that have proliferated across Southeast Asia's legal grey zones — Myanmar, Cambodia, the Philippines — operated by Chinese criminal syndicates with possible ties to state intelligence. Whether Guo herself was a spy or simply a well-placed criminal remains disputed. What is not disputed: she was convicted of human trafficking in November 2025 and sentenced to life in prison.

The Economist's Extraordinary Story this week is the full account — and it's a remarkable piece of reporting. The Alice Guo case captures something important about our moment: the way that the machinery of democratic legitimacy (an election, a mayoralty, a national ID) can be hollowed out from the inside by patient, well-resourced actors operating at a level of patience and sophistication that conventional politics simply doesn't expect. Bamban got a Jollibee and a spy. The story repays every minute you spend on it.

The Restaurant at the End of the World

Why the business model that fed us for a century is cracking up

Here is a statistic that should stop you mid-bite: **42% of American restaurants were unprofitable last year**. Not struggling. Not breaking even. Unprofitable. The Economist ran an extended piece on the restaurant industry this week, and the argument is sweeping: the traditional restaurant — white tablecloth or checked, it doesn't much matter — is losing to a combination of forces that are structural, not cyclical.

The problems are overlapping. Inflation pushed food costs up faster than menus could absorb. Fewer people commute, which gutted the lunch trade in city centres. The delivery-app ecosystem has created a generation of customers who know exactly what they want and don't want to leave the sofa to get it. And then there's the competition for the evening itself: a really good home streaming setup, a sophisticated home cocktail kit, a meal kit from a chef you admire — the evening out now has to justify itself against a properly elevated stay-in. "Dinner and a movie," writes The Economist, "has to up its game to compete with Netflix and chilaquiles."

The restaurants that are surviving and thriving are doing something different. They're selling an *experience* that cannot be replicated at home: the theatre of a tasting menu, the noise and heat of a live-fire kitchen you can watch, the communal energy of a supper club where the whole room is eating the same thing at the same time. They're finding models — counter dining, no-reservations bars, event-led evenings — that squeeze more revenue out of a small footprint. They're leaning into scarcity: if you can only get a seat at Logma's Wednesday Lates if you plan three weeks ahead, that scarcity is part of the product.

London is an interesting test case for all this. The capital's food scene remains genuinely extraordinary — this week alone there are four-hands dinners, a Champagne house collaboration, a New Haven pizza cult getting its first permanent home. But the economics are as brutal here as

anywhere. The restaurants worth watching are the ones that have understood that they're not in the food business anymore. They're in the memory business.

(More on where to go in the Eat section below.)

Short Reads

Ageing Disgracefully

The Economist's weekend report this week had a headline that felt like a prank: "Why people over the age of 55 are the new problem generation." But it turns out the data backs it up entirely. Boomers are drinking more, taking more drugs, and having more casual sex — while Gen Z, that supposedly lost generation, is going to bed early, doing yoga, and taking up crochet.

The explanation, according to the Economist's reporting, isn't simply that the old guard is enjoying a final hedonistic run. The more unsettling reading is that over-55s are exhibiting signs of social disconnection — loneliness, the loss of structure that comes with retirement, the dissolution of the social networks that kept behaviour in check. The fun statistics (more casual sex!) mask something rather less fun (more substance dependency, more risk-taking borne of emptiness rather than joy).

The counterpoint: Gen Z's apparent sobriety and domesticity might itself be a form of disconnection — a retreat from a social world that feels expensive, overwhelming, and surveilled. The generation that grew up being told that everything they did online was permanent has responded by doing less. Whether this is wisdom or withering is the question.

Both generations, in different ways, seem to be struggling with a world that doesn't quite know what to do with them.

Your Private AI Conversations Are Not As Private As You Think

WIRED broke a quietly alarming story this week: private conversations with Claude, Anthropic's AI chatbot, were appearing in Google and Bing search results. Users who had shared a chat link — perhaps to show a friend something interesting — and then deleted the link, found their conversations indexed and publicly searchable.

The screwup illustrates a structural problem with the AI chatbot era: these platforms generate enormous volumes of content — conversations, threads, shared links — and the systems designed

to signal to search-engine crawlers what is and isn't public are fiendishly complex to implement correctly. A misconfigured robots.txt file, an improperly scoped sharing permission, and suddenly a conversation you had about your medical symptoms or your divorce is sitting on page two of a Google search for your name.

Anthropic has since patched the issue. But the incident raises the question worth sitting with: how much do you really know about the privacy settings on the AI tools you use daily? The default assumption — that your conversations are private because you didn't explicitly make them public — may not be as robust as it sounds. These tools are designed to share and collaborate. Privacy has to be actively built in, not assumed.

Also This Week

The Boom Nobody Asked For

The menopause wellness industry is worth nearly \$19 billion — so why do most women still feel like they're on their own?

Walk into any upscale pharmacy and the menopause shelf has quietly colonised half the vitamins aisle. There are cooling sprays and adaptogens, libido gummies and “hormone support” blends, apps that track your hot flushes and connect you with a “menopause coach.” Brands with names like Nova Relief and Minerva Wellness have raised serious money. The global menopause wellness market is valued at \$18.74 billion this year and projected to double to nearly \$38 billion by 2035.

Which makes it odd that, according to a survey of over 15,000 women conducted last year, only 14% of them had learned about menopause from a healthcare professional. Ninety-nine percent said they wanted it included in routine health checks.

Those two figures should produce cognitive dissonance — or rage. We are deep into a cultural moment that Davina McCall effectively kickstarted with her Channel 4 documentaries: menopause is discussed, hashtagged, mainstreamed, turned into a TED talk and a supplement range. And yet the lived experience of most women in the UK remains one of vague symptoms, inadequate appointments, and uneven access to treatments. A major international review published last year found menopause care to be “fragmented and unequal worldwide.” The NHS, to its credit, has just announced menopause will be added to routine health checks — a real, if long-overdue, shift — but it barely scratches the structural problem.

This is Bloomberg Businessweek's cover story this week, and the critique it lands is sharp: the wellness industry has rushed into the gap between women's need and the healthcare system's provision, and what it sells often resembles care without actually being it. Some of it is straightforwardly misleading. This spring, the UK's Advertising Standards Authority found that Minerva Wellness and Nova Relief had broken rules by suggesting their supplements could work like medicines — effectively positioning over-the-counter pills as alternatives to HRT. They cannot. They do not.

HRT itself — real HRT, the kind with robust clinical evidence behind it — has also been in short supply. The trigger was unexpected: in November 2025, the FDA finally removed its outdated boxed warning on menopausal hormone therapy, the relic of a 2002 study that had unfairly frightened women and doctors away from the treatment for over two decades. The resulting demand spike was enormous. Patch use had already tripled between 2018 and early 2026; the post-FDA-reversal surge compressed years of growth into months. Manufacturing capacity was not ready.

There is something almost perfectly dark about this. After decades of being demonised and underprescribed, HRT is vindicated — and the shelves run out. Into the vacuum rushes an industry selling things that are not HRT but look, in the right lighting, a little like it.

The broader pattern is one women's health knows too well: attention without accountability. Genuine medical need, commercial energy, regulatory lag. The question is whether the menopause moment becomes a real turning point in how medicine treats women in midlife — or whether it turns out, like so many wellness revolutions before it, to be mostly something you can buy.

The Continent Is on Fire

Ten thousand dead, 330,000 evacuated, and a summer scientists say would have been virtually impossible without climate change

At the height of last month's fires, the smoke from the Gironde was visible from space. The blaze, which tore through 42,000 hectares of forest south of Bordeaux — one of the largest fires in France since the Second World War — was still burning when a new front opened west of Madrid. That fire merged with a second to form a single inferno across 80,000 hectares of Castilian hillside: the largest in Spain's recorded history. By 1 August, roughly 330,000 people had been forced from their homes across France and Spain alone, with fresh evacuations beginning as the crisis shifted east to Greece, where gale-force winds drove flames through a coastal resort and hundreds fled by sea.

This is the summer Europe is having.

The heatwaves that preceded the fires broke records quietly and then spectacularly. Western Europe's June ran 3.06 degrees Celsius above its recent average — not a rounding error, an epochal number. Heat scientists have been explicit: that June would have been “virtually impossible” without human-induced climate change. And the heat is not incidental to the fires; it is the fires, in a different form — parched soil, dead vegetation, winds that strip moisture from everything they touch.

The death toll from the heat alone is still being tallied. The European mortality monitor EuroMOMO attributes around 10,600 excess deaths to this summer's temperatures so far — including more than 2,700 in Britain. That figure tends to disappear from the news cycle. Heat death is quiet: people die indoors, of causes attributed to the heart or lungs. The aggregate is catastrophic, but it leaves no photograph.

The EU's emergency response infrastructure — rescEU, a fleet of pre-positioned firefighting aircraft — has never been activated at this scale. Twenty-two planes, five helicopters, 777 firefighters drawn from twelve countries, deployed simultaneously. This is the system performing exactly as designed. It is visibly struggling.

The Economist's piece this week frames the fires not as a crisis but as a forecast — its headline calls them “just the start,” and the word *start* is doing real work. Fire scientists and climate modellers are converging on a conclusion that European governments have been slow to absorb: the Mediterranean fire season now resembles what hurricane season looks like in the Atlantic. It is annual, structural, and worsening. Portugal, Spain, France, Greece, and Turkey are not experiencing a run of bad luck. They are experiencing a new climate.

The question left hanging — and it is not a small one — is whether Europe's planning will ever catch up to the summers it is already living through. Building codes, land management, early-warning systems, evacuation infrastructure: all of it calibrated to a climate that no longer exists.

This Week in London History

The Street That Changed How We See in the Dark

The next time you walk down Pall Mall — between St James's Palace and Trafalgar Square, that grand, club-lined thoroughfare — pause for a moment and consider that on the night of 28 January 1807, this street did something no street in the world had ever done before. It turned on its gas lights.

The man responsible was a German immigrant named Frederick Albert Winsor, born Friedrich Albert Winzer in Brunswick. Winsor had patented coal-gas lighting in 1804 and spent years badgering sceptical Londoners to take the idea seriously. His own house on Pall Mall became his laboratory. Then, to celebrate King George III's birthday in June of that year, he lit the entire length of the street — thirteen lamp-posts, each carrying three gas jets — and invited London to gape.

Gape it did. Thomas Rowlandson, the caricaturist, was moved to sketch the spectacle: curious Londoners clustered around the new lights, faces tilted upward, clearly unsure whether to be delighted or suspicious. Both responses were reasonable. Before gas, London after dark was a genuinely dangerous place — lanterns were expensive, candles guttered, link-boys with torches were the only illumination in many streets. Gas changed the city's relationship with night permanently.

Winsor founded the Gas Light and Coke Company in 1812, the world's first gas utility. Within a decade, the technology spread across Europe. By 1823, 40,000 gas lamps covered 215 miles of London's streets. The modern city — the city where night does not mean danger, where you can read on the Tube and walk home after the theatre — has its root in a January night on Pall Mall, 219 years ago.

A plaque on the south side of the street marks the spot. Most people walk past it without glancing.

Viral Thing of the Week

The Ballad of Jimothy

Every so often the internet collectively decides to love something completely harmless, and the result is briefly beautiful. This week's beneficiary is a raccoon named Jimothy.

Jimothy lives in Seattle's Ballard neighbourhood and has, by all accounts, been going about his business there for some time. What makes him internet-famous is his shape. Jimothy appears to have a condition called "short spine syndrome," which means his front and rear legs are very close together, giving his torso an almost perfectly spherical quality. He looks, as one commenter put it, "like a raccoon drawn by someone who had only ever heard raccoons described over the phone."

On 14 July, a local named Kiana Hall filmed Jimothy crossing a patch of grass and climbing a staircase. The video gathered 8 million views. Then it gathered 8 million more. Seattle's city council issued a formal proclamation declaring this "Jimothy Summer." Google produced an

animation. There is now a Jimothy bobblehead. The *Seattle Times* ran an interview with wildlife officials who gently requested that everyone stop trying to visit Jimothy in person, for both Jimothy's sake and their own (raccoons bite).

None of this resolves the actual news of the world. But Jimothy's existence — rotund, unhurried, entirely unbothered by the attention — feels like the appropriate footnote to a fairly relentless week.

EAT

Where to go in London right now

Logma — Haggerston

The best Wednesday night in east London.

What started as a series of sold-out dinner parties at a couple's flat has become, via pop-ups and cult supper clubs, a proper restaurant on Haggerston High Street — and one of the most exciting things to happen to London's dining scene in years. Ziad Halub and Farsin Rabiee bring together the cuisines of Iraq and Iran with a kind of casual authority that makes the food feel both deeply personal and immediately revelatory: lamb and okra stew, saffron chicken with barberry rice, pastries and coffee in the mornings.

The thing to do is book **Logma Lates**, which runs every Wednesday evening. Eighteen seats at a candlelit communal table or the kitchen counter, a £65 set menu, and a room full of people who booked three weeks ago because they'd heard.

Ebi Wines — Clerkenwell

The most considered wine bar in London.

Raku Oda spent years as assistant head sommelier at Heston Blumenthal's The Fat Duck before opening this small, beautiful wine bar on Rosebery Avenue. Every detail is considered: handmade coasters, Japanese-designed cutlery, slender shelves lined with books on ceramics. The food is deliberately minimal — olives, homemade crackers, British cheese, chilled hiyashi tomatoes — because the point is the wine, and the point of the wine is Oda's ability to match you with something you didn't know you needed.

Walk-ins only. Open Wednesday to Saturday 5pm–10:30pm, Sunday 3pm–9:30pm. Go soon, before everyone else does.

Hon's BBQ — Hackney Wick

Texas meets Hong Kong, above a brewery.

Man Hon Luk spent twenty years running the Vinyl Pimp record shop in east London before a poker trip to Austin, Texas, changed the direction of his life entirely. He's now running Hon's BBQ above Crate Brewery in Queen's Yard, Hackney Wick, and the combination — brisket and Sichuan beef short ribs, smoked tea eggs with candied walnuts, Xi'an-style lamb shoulder, everything sold by the gram until it sells out — is exactly as good as it sounds.

Meat is smoked low and slow for up to twelve hours. There are DJ nights and BBQ classes. The whole operation, funded by a crowdfund that raised £36,000 against a £20,000 target, feels like the kind of east London story that in ten years will get cited as the origin point of something bigger.

The Barbary — Notting Hill

A restaurant in its prime.

The Barbary on Westbourne Grove is doing something interesting: building a genuine canon of cooking drawn from the coastline of North Africa and Southern Europe, with a confidence and clarity that's rare. The main restaurant is worth booking on any given week. But this month they've launched a new **Kitchen Counter wine dinner series** — small, intimate evenings where you eat at the counter while the kitchen cooks around you.

The first instalment (4 August, 15 seats, £150 with full Champagne pairing) collaborates with Billecart-Salmon, with courses matched to cuvées from Brut Réserve through to vintage. If it's already sold out — and it may be — get on the list for future editions.

Lenny's Apizza — Covent Garden

Coming soon: a cult gets a home.

Lenny's apizza began as a pop-up in a pub in Finsbury Park, serving New Haven-style pizza — that's "ah-beetz," the style developed by Italian immigrants in Connecticut in the early 1900s: oblong, charred, irregular, defined by tomato and pecorino with mozzarella treated as optional. It

went viral, it sold out every week, and it has spent the past year making people in north London very happy.

This autumn, it's getting a permanent home on Henrietta Street in Covent Garden, in partnership with the team behind Casa do Frango and KOL. Not open yet, but worth knowing about, and worth booking the moment reservations open.

EVENTS

Things to put in the diary

Music

Sunday 2 August — Ronnie Scott's Gospel Choir, 47 Frith Street, Soho. Led by Daniel Thomas: soaring harmonies, uplifting classics, high energy and a room that will be on its feet. Two shows, 2pm and 8pm. **Tickets from £30.**

Tuesday 4 August — Bruno Heinen Trio, Ronnie Scott's. Described by The Guardian as "eclectic, eccentric and unobtrusively erudite" — piano-led jazz that draws from classical and contemporary with striking originality. **From £25.**

Wednesday 5 and Thursday 6 August — Denny Ilett's Electric Lady Big Band, Ronnie Scott's. A 16-piece ensemble performing arrangements of Jimi Hendrix's entire catalogue. This sounds like it should be naff and is almost certainly transcendent. Two shows per night, 6:40pm and 9:15pm. **From £40.**

Wednesday 12 August — Philip Lassiter, Ronnie Scott's. Trumpeter and horn arranger who played in Prince's New Power Generation. Deep, authoritative funk. Two shows. **From £45.**

Thursday 20 August — **Miles Davis Centenary**, BBC Proms, Royal Albert Hall. A concert marking 100 years since the birth of the greatest jazz musician who ever lived. Conductor Miho Hazama leads the BBC Concert Orchestra alongside trumpeter Ambrose Akinmusire in new arrangements drawn from *Miles Ahead*, *Porgy and Bess*, *Sketches of Spain*, and *Quiet Nights*. Broadcast on BBC TV. **Book at royalalberthall.com.**

Monday 31 August — Enchanted: Alan Menken's Music for Disney, BBC Proms, Royal Albert Hall. An evening of the music from *The Little Mermaid*, *Beauty and the Beast*, *Aladdin*, *Pocahontas*, and more. Do not pretend you don't want to go. **7pm.**

Just Announced at the Royal Albert Hall

Not August events, but these are booking now and worth getting ahead of:

- **Tuesday 6 October** — Aaron Tveit: Broadway star of *Moulin Rouge!* and *Next to Normal*, in London for one night.
 - **Monday 12 October** — Classic FM Live with Viking: Dan Walker and Mylene Klass host a space-inspired evening with the Philharmonia Orchestra.
 - **Wednesday 11 November** — The Adam and Joe Show: Adam Buxton and Joe Cornish reunite to celebrate 30 years of their show, with clips, big-screen retro-ramblings, and stories. The sell-out risk is high on this one.
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Food & Drinks Events

Monday 4 August — The Barbary x Billecart-Salmon Kitchen Counter Dinner, Westbourne Grove, Notting Hill. Five courses, Champagne pairings from Brut Réserve to vintage cuvée, just 15 seats at the kitchen counter. **£150. Book via sevenrooms.**

Tuesday 5 August (and 2 September) — Hoppers Dosa Deep House, King's Cross. Sri Lankan curries, dosas, sunset DJ sets from emerging South Asian artists. Coincides with the return of Hoppers' limited-edition Kalupol Chicken Bun. **Free entry.**

Thursday 6 August — LIMA Four-Hands Dinner, Fitzrovia. Head chef Diego Recarte (LIMA) teams up with Milton Fragozo (formerly of Mirazur R&D). Seven courses, Pisco Sour on arrival. **£90. Email Enquiry@limalondon.com or call 020 3002 2640.**

Thursday 7 August — International Beer Day, Guinness Open Gate Brewery, Old Brewer's Yard, Covent Garden. They are giving away 100 free pints from midday — Guinness, Guinness 0.0, or craft beers. Turn up. **Free.**

Friday 8 – Saturday 9 August — KERB Goes East, Round The Dock, Canada Water. 50+ street food traders serving Sichuan noodles, Korean tacos, bao, bánh mì, Filipino barbecue. Live music, lion dancing, taiko drumming, East Asian makers market. **Free.**

Talks (Pints of Knowledge)

If you haven't been to a Pints of Knowledge evening, the idea is simple: interesting people explain things in pubs. The line-up for August includes some particularly good options:

- **Tuesday 4 August** — *Corrupted Kingdom: Why the UK Is Becoming More Corrupt*, The Landor Pub, Clapham, SW9
- **Wednesday 5 August** — *Why Doctor Doom Is Better Than Batman* (don't dismiss this one — it's a seriously good talk about moral philosophy via comic books), The George IV, Chiswick
- **Tuesday 11 August** — *Memento Mori: The Victorian Way of Death*, Big Penny Social, Walthamstow
- **Monday 10 August** — *A "Hot" Future: How Nuclear is the Future for Medicine*, Old Queen's Head, Islington

All events are ticketed (mostly £10–£15) and typically sell out. pintsofknowledge.co.uk

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Sources: The Economist, Bloomberg Businessweek, WIRED, Hot Dinners, Ronnie Scott's, Royal Albert Hall, Pints of Knowledge; web research via Timeout London, Broadsheet, The Nudge, The Infatuation, and multiple event listings.